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3.2 Original Writing & Commentary (NEA)

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Non-Exam Assessment: Language in Action

> The Original Writing task asks you to produce a **750-word original piece** in one of three genre areas, accompanied by a **750-word reflective commentary**. You must also submit an **annotated style model**. This is half of the 20% NEA grade. It is your chance to demonstrate BOTH creative/productive competence AND analytical self-awareness.

Three Genre Areas for Original Writing

Power of Persuasion	Power of Storytelling	Power of Information
investigative journalism speeches open letters, columns	short stories biography extracts dramatic monologues	travel journalism blogs local history
changing minds / acting	narrative craft	engaging & informing

3.2.1 The Three Genre Areas

The Power of Persuasion

Texts that aim to change the reader\'s view or move them to action. Examples:

- Investigative journalism — longer-form articles on an issue.
- Speeches — campaign, political, ceremonial.
- Open letters — addressed to a public figure or institution.
- Opinion columns.
- Campaign texts — leaflets, manifestos.

The Power of Storytelling

Texts that narrate an experience, event or imagined situation. Examples:

- Short stories.
- Biography extracts.
- Dramatic monologues.
- Short screenplays.
- Travel memoir passages.

The Power of Information

Texts that inform an audience while engaging them. Examples:

- Travel journalism (more informational than memoir).
- Blogs (on a specialist topic).
- Local history pieces.
- Feature articles (e.g. science writing for a lay audience).

3.2.2 The Style Model

Choose one published text as your **style model**. It should be:

- In the same genre as your original piece.
- Of a length broadly similar to yours.
- Well-crafted and published (not a student piece).
- Rich enough to annotate usefully.

You must **annotate** it — marking up features you are learning from and intending to use or adapt. Both the original style model and your annotated version accompany your submission.

The commentary repeatedly references the style model: what you adopted, what you adapted, what you deliberately did differently, and why. This is how you demonstrate informed craft rather than imitation.

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Genre area	Suggested style models
Persuasion	Hari Kunzru, Caitlin Moran, Tim Harford columns; Michelle Obama or Barack Obama speeches; James Baldwin\'s open letters.
Storytelling	Kazuo Ishiguro short fiction; Alan Bennett\'s *Talking Heads* monologues; Claudia Rankine\'s lyrical prose.
Information	Robert Macfarlane nature writing; Hanif Kureishi or Colson Whitehead essays; a longform blog post from a science or history writer.

3.2.3 Craft Principles Across Genres

Whatever your genre, strong writing displays:

- **Audience awareness** — every lexical, grammatical and graphological choice responds to your reader.
- **Purpose clarity** — every paragraph moves the purpose forward.
- **Register consistency** — or deliberate, signalled shifts.
- **Syntactic variety** — mix of sentence lengths and structures for rhythm.
- **Concrete detail** — named, sensory, specific.
- **Controlled structure** — clear opening, purposeful middle, satisfying end.

3.2.4 Techniques by Genre Area

Persuasion

- **Triadic / rule-of-three** structures for memorable rhythm.
- **Parallelism** — repeated grammatical shapes for emphasis.
- **Inclusive "we"** and direct address — positioning the audience.
- **Modal verbs of obligation** — "must", "should".
- **Rhetorical questions** — engaging the reader\'s reasoning.

- **Anecdote opening** — humanising an argument before making its broader points.
- **Imperative call to action** — usually in the closing.
- **Statistics + expert testimony** — balancing emotional appeal with evidential weight.

Storytelling

- **Strong narrative voice** — consistent idiolect across the piece.
- **Show, don\'t tell** — concrete detail, sensory specificity.
- **Scene and summary** — scene-building for key moments, summary to bridge.
- **Dialogue** — character-revealing, not just plot-moving.
- **Pacing** — sentence length and paragraphing controlling speed.
- **In medias res opening** — starting mid-action to grip.
- **Dramatic irony** (esp. monologues) — reader infers more than narrator says.
- **Structural resolution** — ending that pays off the opening.

Information

- **Clear opening hook** — anecdote, question or surprising fact.
- **Logical structure** — chronological, thematic or comparative.
- **Integration of fact** — weaving data into narrative flow.
- **Accessible register** — technical terms introduced and explained.
- **First-person voice** (if appropriate) — bringing personal perspective.
- **Sub-headings** — (where genre conventions allow) aiding navigation.
- **Reflective closing** — drawing together the information with a thoughtful conclusion.

3.2.5 The Commentary

The 750-word commentary is analytical, not creative. It is your chance to demonstrate AO1 (methods), AO2 (concepts), AO3 (context) in relation to your own writing.

What the commentary must do

- Explain your **intended audience** and **purpose**.
- Discuss your **style model** — what you adopted, what you adapted, what you deliberately did differently.
- Analyse your **linguistic choices** at multiple levels (lexis, grammar, graphology, pragmatics), using precise terminology.
- Quote specific phrases from your own piece as evidence.
- Reflect honestly on what worked and what did not — including alternatives considered.

Commentary paragraph structure

A reliable structure:

1. **Feature identified** — "My opening uses a fronted prepositional phrase…"
2. **Quotation from your piece** — "'Beyond the ridge, she waited.'"
3. **Framework terminology** — "The fronting delays the subject and foregrounds place (grammatical marked order)."
4. **Effect on reader** — "This builds a sense of suspense and orients the reader spatially before introducing the protagonist."
5. **Link to style model** — "I adapted this technique from Kazuo Ishiguro\'s opening in *The Remains of the Day*, which I annotated for its use of spatial fronting to construct reflective narration."

> **Worked Example:** Strong commentary sentence (Persuasion, speech on climate action): "*The triadic imperative close — 'Act. Demand. Change.' — draws on Obama\'s 2008 victory speech, my style model, which I annotated for its rhythmic three-part closers. Cutting the connectives creates urgency (minor sentences) and leaves the audience with a directive voice (imperative mood). An earlier draft used \'We must act, demand and change\' — polysyndetic and less punchy; I revised for sharper impact.*" Notice: quotation + framework + effect + style model + revision reflection, all in three sentences.

3.2.6 What the Commentary Should NOT Do

- **Retell the plot** — the reader has just read the piece.

- **Merely describe** — "I used an adjective" without explaining the effect is AO1 at its weakest.
- **Ignore the style model** — failing to reference it misses the entire point of the exercise.
- **Avoid frameworks** — you must use the six linguistic levels and their terminology.
- **Only praise yourself** — honest critical reflection is valued.

3.2.7 Tips for Drafting

1. Choose your genre area and a style model *before* drafting the original piece.
2. Annotate the style model carefully — identify 6–10 features you want to learn from.
3. Write the piece with those features in mind. Don\'t copy — learn from.
4. After a draft, note the choices you made consciously. These become commentary material.
5. Revise the piece. Keep notes of what you cut and why — these are commentary gold.
6. Draft the commentary paragraph by paragraph, each one quoting from your piece.
7. Check every commentary paragraph links back to the style model OR to purpose / audience / context.
8. Proof-read both — commentary and original — as separate acts of writing.

3.2.8 Plagiarism and Originality

Your original piece must be your own work. You can learn from your style model but you cannot lift its phrasing. Informed adaptation (e.g. using the same RHETORICAL TECHNIQUE with your own content) is expected and rewarded. Direct copying of wording is plagiarism and disqualifying.

Your teacher can advise on scope, genre and methodology. They cannot write or rewrite the piece. Keep drafts to demonstrate the development of your work.

3.2.9 Example Project Plan

Week	Task

1	Choose genre area. Read widely in that area.
2	Select and annotate a style model.
3	Plan the original piece — audience, purpose, outline.
4	Draft 1 of the original piece.
5	Draft 1 of the commentary. Use this to clarify intentions.
6	Revise the original piece informed by commentary draft.
7	Revise the commentary to match the final original piece.
8	Proof-read both and submit.

NEA Tip: The commentary should feel as crafted as the original piece. Treat it as an act of writing in its own right, using academic register, precise terminology, integrated quotation and honest reflection.

3.2.10 Assessment Objectives for the NEA

The two components together assess:

- **AO1** — Apply appropriate methods of language analysis using associated terminology and coherent written expression (commentary).
- **AO2** — Demonstrate critical understanding of concepts and issues relevant to language use (commentary).
- **AO3** — Analyse and evaluate how contextual factors and language features are associated with the construction of meaning (commentary).
- **AO5** — Demonstrate expertise and creativity in the use of English (original piece).

AO5 applies specifically to the original piece. The commentary is where you demonstrate AO1, AO2 and AO3 in relation to your own writing.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **genre area (persuasion / storytelling / information), style model, annotation, audience, purpose, register, idiolect, narrative voice, triadic structure, parallelism, anaphora, modality, inclusive "we", anecdote, in medias res, dramatic irony, sensory imagery, concrete vs abstract lexis, register shift, commentary.** Also know the **AO descriptors** and how they apply to each component.

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